

# THREE RIVERS

# GO DARK

## Instructor Edition & Exercise Control Guide

FOR EXERCISE CONTROL  
INJECTS • NOTES • MODEL RESPONSES

### Pittsburgh Zombie Response & Recovery Tabletop

Designed for the Prepare Thyself common foundation and credential tracks

## Instructor quick start

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**Fiction and boundaries:** The scenario contains zombies, blood, bodies, unsettling sounds, and implied deaths. It does not require students to describe gore, act out attacks, touch classmates, or decide who deserves to die. Let any student step into a documentation/observer role without penalty.

### Purpose

Students experience how the common foundation—IS-100, IS-700, sandbagging, heat-injury awareness, and optional SKYWARN—connects the three specialization tracks during one Pittsburgh incident. The exercise rewards disciplined communication and support work rather than heroic freelancing.

### Recommended format

| Format               | Time           | Use                                                                           |
|----------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Single-period sprint | 55–65 minutes  | Use Injects 1, 2, 4, 6, and 8.                                                |
| Full tabletop        | 90–110 minutes | Use all eight injects and a ten-minute hotwash.                               |
| Two-class exercise   | 2 × 60 minutes | Pause after Inject 4; require a written incident action plan before resuming. |

### Materials

- One student exercise book per student or team
- One cut-apart role card per student
- Printed inject cards from the end of this guide

- Large Pittsburgh-area map or projected CalTopo practice map
- Sticky notes, markers, message forms, resource board, and timer
- Optional classroom radios used only on authorized channels/settings

## Never simulate

- Actual emergency calls, live amateur/public-safety radio traffic, or drone launch without a separate authorized plan
- Weapons, physical restraint, biting, blood application, or surprise physical contact
- Student personal medical histories, home addresses, or family-reunification status

## Learning objectives and evaluation

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By the end, students should be able to:

1. Use ICS roles, objectives, chain of command, and span of control.
2. Apply NIMS ideas: common terminology, resource management, interoperability, mutual aid, and whole-community coordination.
3. Distinguish verified facts from reports, assumptions, and rumors.
4. Match assignments to capabilities, credentials, supervision, and legal limits.
5. Create a shared map/status picture and maintain accountability.
6. Support sheltering, feeding, safety, supply, and early recovery.
7. Revise a plan when new information invalidates it.

## Exercise success is not “killing all zombies”

A successful group protects people, preserves responder safety, establishes reliable information, supports adult authorities, keeps records, and creates a sustainable recovery plan. Students should discover that radio logs, food temperatures, team status, maps, weather reports, and safe work rules can matter as much as field action.

## Suggested scoring

| Dimension         | 4                                                | 3                      | 2                            | 1                     |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------|
| ICS/NIMS          | Clear objectives, roles, command, accountability | Mostly organized       | Roles exist but are bypassed | Freelancing dominates |
| Information       | Sources, times, verification, maps and logs      | Most key facts tracked | Incomplete records           | Rumor treated as fact |
| Capability limits | Every task matched to training/supervision       | Minor gaps corrected   | Repeated overreach           | Unsafe deployment     |
| Track integration | All three tracks shape decisions                 | All tracks used        | One track sidelined          | Specialists ignored   |
| Recovery          | Sustainable May 1 plan                           | Basic transition       | Response only                | No continuity         |

## Setup and role assignment

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### Before students arrive

1. Print the student books and role cards. Keep this instructor guide private.
2. Choose the exercise duration and injects.
3. Display the six sectors. If using CalTopo, create a fictional practice map without private student data.
4. Place an incoming-message station away from command so message runners matter.
5. Decide whether “adult agency control” is played by you or another adult.

### Assignment order

Assign Command first, then the three track groups. For a large class, duplicate logger, map, supply, radio, shelter, and safety cards and label them A/B. For a small class, combine roles as shown.

| Students | Recommended grouping                                                                                                                                 |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10–12    | Combine IC/liaison; PIO/logger; communications/net control; map/documentation; operations/drone; medical/safety; logistics/supply; shelter/recovery. |
| 13–18    | Use all 16 cards; duplicate message logger and map/supply support as needed.                                                                         |
| 19–30    | Create paired assistants, a second operational-period planning team, and two shelter/supply teams. Keep span of control near 3–7.                    |

### Opening prompt

“At 07:00, Pittsburgh is dark. The tunnel lights are dead, the rivers are rising, and something on the other side of the loading-dock door has been scraping the same four notes into the steel since 03:17. You have skills, certificates, a frightened shelter population, and incomplete contact with the adults in charge. Build an organization before the city gets worse.”

**Facilitator move:** Give students 8–10 minutes to name an Incident Commander, build only the positions needed, write three measurable objectives, and identify what information must be verified. Do not rescue them from early confusion; use it in the debrief.

## Ground truth

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This information belongs to exercise control. Reveal it only through injects or successful student inquiry.

| Question        | Ground truth                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Senior building | Six people are upstairs: four residents, one aide, and one maintenance worker. The lower floor is flooded. They are stable for several hours. Remote contact and adult water-rescue coordination are |

safer than student deployment.

|                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Feverish shelter resident | The blood is from helping an injured neighbor; no bite is visible. The resident has heat exhaustion and severe anxiety. Isolation, PPE, basic care, and adult medical consultation are appropriate. Public accusation is harmful. |
| Warehouse supplies        | Some supplies exist, but smoke, unstable shelving, and zombie movement make entry unsafe. A remote inventory and adult-agency request are appropriate.                                                                            |
| Drone mission             | Weather and a temporary helicopter corridor make immediate launch unsafe. Later, a limited supervised flight becomes possible after coordination and a new risk check.                                                            |
| Radio “child”             | The voice is a looped recording from an abandoned phone/radio near a maintenance corridor. It is designed to lure impulsive action. Signal direction and repetition expose it.                                                    |
| Water                     | One pallet is contaminated by a cracked industrial-cleaner container. Inventory controls and quarantine prevent illness.                                                                                                          |
| Storm                     | Heavy rain produces rapid street flooding. Sandbagging can protect the generator area but only if started before the worst rain and managed safely.                                                                               |
| May 1                     | The immediate wave is contained outside several hot zones. The cohort is needed for communications, mapping, shelter support, logistics, documentation, and cleanup planning—not zombie contact.                                  |

**Desired overall strategy:** stabilize the site; separate medical concerns without stigma; establish redundant communications; verify and map reports; coordinate adult rescue for the senior building; delay unsafe drone/warehouse operations; protect generator and supplies from floodwater; counter rumors; and prepare a documented shift into recovery.

## Master sequence

| Time | Inject                              | Primary roles tested                 | Decision pressure                         |
|------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| +10  | 1. Blood on the sleeve              | Medical, Safety, IC, PIO             | Care versus panic and stigma              |
| +20  | 2. Six voices above the brown water | Planning, SAR, Liaison, Comms        | Rescue urgency versus capability          |
| +30  | 3. The whispering radio             | Net Control, Logger, Planning        | Emotion versus verification               |
| +40  | 4. Eyes in the gray sky             | Drone, Safety, Planning, IC          | Useful technology versus airspace/weather |
| +50  | 5. Free water                       | Supply, OSHA, Shelter, Finance/Admin | Speed versus inspection/accountability    |

|     |                                   |                                     |                                            |
|-----|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| +60 | 6. The river climbs the steps     | SKYWARN, Sandbag, Logistics, Safety | Protect infrastructure under time pressure |
| +70 | 7. The lie with a thousand shares | PIO, Liaison, IC, Comms             | Rumor control and privacy                  |
| +80 | 8. Dawn inventory                 | All tracks                          | Transition from response to recovery       |

## Controller technique

- Release each inject as a written message, radio readout, or witness report.
- Ask, “Who owns this?” before allowing the whole class to shout solutions.
- If students jump straight to action, ask for objective, authority, hazards, supervision, communications, and return/accountability plan.
- If they stall, offer two imperfect options rather than the answer.
- Reward people who document, verify, or stop an unsafe plan.

## Injects 1–2

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### Inject 1 — Blood on the sleeve

07:18. A shelter volunteer points at the feverish adult. Dark blood has soaked through the left sleeve. Someone shouts, “They’re turning.” Chairs scrape backward. A child begins crying. The adult sways and whispers, “Please—water.”

**Give to:** Medical Support or Message Logger.

**Expected actions:** scene safety; PPE; calm separation from crowd; basic assessment within training; adult medical consultation; hydration/cooling if appropriate; preserve dignity; PIO rumor control; document exposure facts.

**Complication if mishandled:** panic causes a fall injury and the rumor spreads outside.

**Model direction:** Do not assume infection from fever or blood. The blood came from assisting another person. The correct process protects the shelter while avoiding diagnosis or public labeling.

**Ask:** Who may assess? What can a CPR/first-aid card actually authorize? What should the public hear?

### Inject 2 — Six voices above the brown water

07:31. A broken phone call reaches the site. Six people are trapped on the third floor of a senior building near the Monongahela. Water pushes dead leaves, bottles, and something pale against the lobby glass. The caller says the stairwell door is bending inward.

**Give to:** Communications Unit.

**Expected actions:** verify location/count/conditions; log source/time; map as reported; establish remote contact; request adult fire/water rescue through Liaison; gather building/access information; prepare but do not deploy student searchers.

**Useful student contribution:** map packet, communications plan, survivor questions, resource request, weather/flood monitoring.

**Model direction:** The situation is urgent but does not justify sending minors through floodwater. Make the adult rescue request specific and keep the callers informed.

**Ask:** What does SAR support look like when field deployment is outside your capability?

## Injects 3–4

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### Inject 3 — The whispering radio

07:46. A weak voice appears every 43 seconds on a monitored channel: “Help me. It’s dark. I’m under the street.” Then three taps. Then static. The voice sounds like a child. Each transmission is exactly the same length.

**Give to:** Net Control.

**Expected actions:** log exact interval/content; attempt safe verification; ask partner stations whether they receive it; map likely signal observations; recognize possible recording/interference; do not dispatch on emotion alone.

**Clue on good inquiry:** waveform, wording, and background click repeat identically. It is a looped recording.

**Horror reward:** A second voice briefly says the name of your coordination site. It may be accidental interference; it should still be logged.

**Model direction:** Maintain monitoring and pass the report to adult authorities. No student goes underground.

### Inject 4 — Eyes in the gray sky

08:02. Visibility improves. A drone could view the senior building and flooded streets without sending a team. At the same moment, a helicopter is heard to the east and the SKYWARN spotter reports lowering clouds, gusty wind, and lightning ten miles away.

**Give to:** Drone Mission Planner.

**Expected actions:** define objective; check airspace/temporary restrictions/weather; coordinate with adult remote PIC and public safety; plan visual line of sight, crew, abort criteria, altitude, batteries, and image handling; delay launch if aircraft/weather conflict exists.

**Model direction:** Initially no-go. The PIC cannot guarantee separation or safe weather. Students can prepare the mission, map grid, checklist, and imagery log. Later control may announce a narrow safe window.

**Listen for:** Students correctly stating that the adult certificated PIC remains responsible and can immediately take control.

## Injects 5–6

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### Inject 5 — Free water

08:17. A box truck arrives with shrink-wrapped water, canned food, bleach, batteries, and cleaning chemicals. The driver refuses to give a name and leaves. One corner of the truck bed is wet. Several water cases smell sharply sweet.

**Give to:** Supply & Inventory.

**Expected actions:** control receiving area; keep exits clear; use PPE; inspect and segregate; quarantine contaminated water/chemicals; inventory source/time/condition; do not distribute unknown product; notify Safety and Shelter.

**Ground truth:** An industrial-cleaner bottle cracked and contaminated one pallet. Other sealed cases may be usable only after adult safety/public-health review.

**Model direction:** “Free” does not mean ready to issue. The best team creates an orderly receiving, quarantine, and release process.

**Ask:** Which OSHA controls come before PPE? Who records donation value and loss?

## **Inject 6 — The river climbs the steps**

08:31. Rain hits the roof like thrown gravel. Water rises through a clogged drain toward the generator enclosure. The SKYWARN spotter receives a flash-flood warning. The generator has four hours of fuel. Without it, radios, refrigeration, lighting, and medical-device charging stop.

**Give to:** SKYWARN Spotter and Logistics.

**Expected actions:** confirm warning; shelter from lightning; report observed flooding from safety; protect/relocate critical supplies; safely clear only accessible debris; establish sandbag roles and work/rest/accountability; keep exhaust and electrical hazards controlled; prioritize power loads.

**Model direction:** Start early, use a Safety Officer, and protect the generator without placing students in moving water or electrical danger. Consider higher-ground relocation and load reduction, not only sandbags.

**Optional timed challenge:** Teams have five minutes to draw a safe sandbag and drainage plan; score safety, stable placement, flow path, and staffing.

## **Injects 7–8**

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### **Inject 7 — The lie with a thousand shares**

08:47. A social post claims, “STUDENT DRONE TEAM CONFIRMS 200 ZOMBIES INSIDE PITTSBURGH HOSPITAL—CITY HIDING IT.” The image is a blurry screenshot from your practice map. Frightened survivors start demanding evacuation. A television reporter requests confirmation.

**Give to:** PIO.

**Expected actions:** verify internally; preserve screenshot; coordinate with hospital/city through Liaison; issue a prompt correction without amplifying tactical details; state what is known, actions people should take, and next update time; investigate map-sharing settings.

**Ground truth:** The “200” was a student-drawn exercise polygon label, not a count.

**Model release:** “We have no verified report of 200 infected persons at a Pittsburgh hospital. The circulated image is not an operational count. Hospitals and public-safety agencies remain the authoritative sources. Do not travel toward hospital areas. Our next update will be at 09:15.”

**Ask:** How can Planning share enough information for coordination without feeding rumors?

## **Inject 8 — Dawn inventory**

09:02. Adult authorities report that the immediate surge has slowed. Some blocks remain hot zones. The dead lie beneath sheets at intersections; rainwater around them has turned pink and runs toward the storm drains. The city requests a 24-hour support plan: communications, maps, shelter, food, supplies, volunteer accountability, flood protection, damage records, and safe cleanup planning.

**Give to:** Incident Commander.

**Expected product:** a May 1 operational plan with objectives, organization, shift/relief plan, capability limits, resource needs, public message, safety controls, and track-specific assignments.

**Model direction:** Students remain in safe support roles. Biohazard cleanup, body recovery, utilities, demolition, and hot-zone work go to qualified adults. Recovery begins with records, sanitation, reunification, supplies, communications, and sustainable staffing.

**End condition:** Give teams 8–10 minutes, then require each track to brief its contribution in 60 seconds.

## **What strong track performance looks like**

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### **Emergency Communications**

- Builds a PACE communications plan rather than assuming one radio system.
- Uses directed-net discipline, message precedence, call signs, timestamps, repeats, and closures.
- Integrates SKYWARN reports without unsafe observation.
- Supports PIO rumor correction and protects sensitive information.

### **SAR Operations**

- Creates a time-stamped common operating picture with verified/unverified labels.
- Uses CalTopo operational periods, assignments, clues, hazards, and map packets.
- Maintains team briefing, communications, equipment, and return accountability.
- Plans drone use around mission need, airspace, weather, adult PIC authority, and abort criteria.
- Uses remote methods and adult agency requests when student field deployment is unsafe.

### **Disaster Logistics and Recovery**

- Tracks resources from request through receipt, issue, return, and demobilization.
- Uses ServSafe knowledge for food flow, allergens, temperature, sanitation, and waste.
- Uses OSHA hazard awareness and hierarchy of controls accurately.
- Protects generator, water, PPE, communications, sanitation, and staff endurance.
- Plans for shifts, donations, records, reunification, and safe transition to recovery.

**Correct credential language:** CalTopo/NASAR provides a course-completion certificate. OSHA 10 provides a course-completion card, not an OSHA certification. ServSafe Food Handler is a certificate, not Food Protection Manager certification. CPR/AED cards require the program's hands-on skills component. Part 107 PIC authority remains with the certificated adult.



# Facilitation traps and redirections

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| If students say...                              | Ask or redirect...                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Send everyone to rescue them."                 | Who supervises? What hazards, communications, capability, transport, and return plan exist? What remote or adult-agency option is safer? |
| "Shoot/attack the zombies."                     | That is outside this cohort's mission. What support function protects more people without creating another casualty?                     |
| "The person has a fever, so exile them."        | What is verified? What humane isolation, PPE, medical consultation, privacy, and shelter plan is appropriate?                            |
| "Just fly the drone."                           | Who is PIC? What airspace, weather, people, emergency aircraft, VLOS, Remote ID, and abort criteria apply?                               |
| "Post everything so people know."               | What is verified? Whose privacy or safety could be harmed? Who is the authoritative source?                                              |
| "Take every donation."                          | How will it be inspected, quarantined, inventoried, stored, issued, and removed if unusable?                                             |
| "I have OSHA/CPR/SAR training, so I can do it." | What exactly did that credential assess? What supervision and site-specific authorization are still required?                            |
| "We finished the rescue, so we're done."        | Who needs food, sanitation, relief, reunification, documentation, resupply, public information, and recovery support tomorrow?           |

## Make it creepy without losing the lesson

- Use sound descriptions, shadows, abandoned objects, repeated radio messages, and unsettling evidence.
- Let the frightening detail create an information or safety problem.
- Do not reward graphic storytelling more than good decisions.
- Keep students as support personnel, never targets or victims based on real traits.

## Hotwash and after-action review

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### Immediate discussion

1. What was the first moment your original plan stopped working?
2. Which message was most important? Was it logged and closed?
3. When did a credential expand capability? When did its limits matter?
4. Which role looked unimportant at first but became essential?
5. What was the safest way to help the senior-building residents?
6. How did weather change the incident?
7. What information should never have been public?
8. What must this cohort complete before serving together on May 1?

## Improvement plan

| Observation | Strength or gap | Corrective action | Owner | Due date |
|-------------|-----------------|-------------------|-------|----------|
|-------------|-----------------|-------------------|-------|----------|

### Credential follow-through

At the next weekly check-in, every student should connect one exercise failure or success to an artifact in the individual plan: FEMA certificate, radio practice score, SKYWARN registration, CalTopo map, Part 107 study record, CPR skills appointment, ServSafe certificate, OSHA progress, or documentation product.

**Best final realization:** A resilient cohort is not a collection of heroes. It is a system of trained people who know their roles, limits, communications, records, partners, and next operational period.

## Cut-apart controller inject cards

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### 1 — Blood on the Sleeve

**Release +10 minutes**

“A volunteer points at the feverish adult. Dark blood has soaked through the sleeve. Someone shouts, ‘They’re turning.’ Chairs scrape backward. A child cries. The adult whispers, ‘Please—water.’”

**Deliver to:** Medical or Logger

**Watch for:** PPE, calm separation, no diagnosis, medical consult, privacy, PIO.

**Reveal on proper assessment:** no visible bite; blood came from helping an injured neighbor.

### 2 — Six Voices

**Release +20 minutes**

“Six people are trapped on the third floor near the Monongahela. Floodwater pushes debris and something pale against the lobby glass. The stairwell door is bending inward.”

**Deliver to:** Communications

**Watch for:** verification, map, adult rescue request, continued contact, no student deployment.

**Reveal:** callers are stable for several hours if reassured and monitored.

### 3 — Whispering Radio

**Release +30 minutes**

“Every 43 seconds: ‘Help me. It’s dark. I’m under the street.’ Three taps. Static. The voice sounds like a child. Every transmission is the same length.”

**Deliver to:** Net Control

**Watch for:** exact logging, triangulation/inquiry, no impulsive dispatch.

**Reveal:** wording and background click are identical; likely a looped recording.

## **4 — Eyes in the Gray Sky**

**Release +40 minutes**

“A drone could view the flood. A helicopter is heard east. Lowering clouds, gusty wind, and lightning are reported.”

**Deliver to:** Drone Planner

**Watch for:** PIC, airspace, weather, VLOS, mission objective, abort criteria.

**Ruling:** initial no-go; planning continues. Offer a later safe window if their plan is complete.

## **5 — Free Water**

**Release +50 minutes**

“An anonymous truck leaves water, food, bleach, batteries, and cleaning chemicals. The bed is wet. Several water cases smell sharply sweet.”

**Deliver to:** Supply

**Watch for:** controlled receiving, inspection, quarantine, source and condition log, no distribution.

**Reveal:** one industrial-cleaner container cracked.

## **6 — The River Climbs**

**Release +60 minutes**

“A flash-flood warning arrives. Water is moving toward the generator. Four hours of fuel remain. Radios, refrigeration, light, and medical charging depend on it.”

**Deliver to:** SKYWARN and Logistics

**Watch for:** safe observation, shelter, early sandbag plan, electrical/exhaust controls, relocation and load priorities.

## **7 — The Lie**

**Release +70 minutes**

“A viral post says a student drone confirmed 200 zombies inside a Pittsburgh hospital. The image is a blurry screenshot from your map. A reporter asks for confirmation.”

**Deliver to:** PIO

**Watch for:** verify, preserve, coordinate, correct promptly, protect details, next update.

**Reveal:** 200 was a practice polygon label.

## **8 — Dawn Inventory**

**Release +80 minutes**

“The immediate surge has slowed. Hot zones remain. Rainwater around covered bodies runs pink toward storm drains. The city requests a 24-hour support plan for May 1.”

**Deliver to:** IC

**Require:** objectives, roles, shift plan, limits, resources, safety, public message, and all three track briefings.

END OF INSTRUCTOR EDITION • CONTROL THE EXERCISE. DO NOT LET THE EXERCISE CONTROL YOU.